religions

MDPI

Article

Integrating African Indigenous Knowledge Systems (AIKSs) into Public Theology: Towards Contextualized Theological Engagement in Southern Africa

Patrick Nanthambwe

The Unit for Reformational Theology and the Development of the South African Society, Faculty of Theology, North-West University, Potchefstroom 2531, South Africa; patricknanthambwe@yahoo.com

Abstract

The call to decolonize South African university curricula continues to shape academic discourse, highlighting the urgency of integrating African Indigenous Knowledge Systems (AIKSs) into theological education. While Western epistemologies have long dominated theology in Africa, this article argues for a paradigm shift by positioning public theology as a viable framework for engaging AIKS in meaningful and transformative ways. The article examines how AIKSs—expressed through oral traditions, communal spiritualities, and indigenous ethics—can enrich theological discourse, enhance contextual relevance, and address issues such as social justice, identity, and community cohesion. Drawing on the decoloniality discourse, this study critically explores the epistemological, institutional, and pedagogical challenges hindering integration and proposes concrete strategies including curriculum reform, faculty training, and community-based theological formation. The article contributes to the decolonization of theological education by offering a context-specific framework that repositions AIKSs as legitimate theological resources. In doing so, it advances a model of public theology that is inclusive, rooted in African realities, and responsive to the transformative needs of Southern African societies.

Keywords: African indigenous knowledge; public theology; public life; African context; theological engagement; Southern Africa; decolonization of knowledge

check for updates

Academic Editor: Kenneth L. Waters

Received: 28 May 2025
Revised: 23 June 2025
Accepted: 2 July 2025
Published: 4 July 2025

Citation: Nanthambwe, Patrick. 2025. Integrating African Indigenous Knowledge Systems (AIKSs) into Public Theology: Towards Contextualized Theological Engagement in Southern Africa. *Religions* 16: 869. https://doi.org/10.3390/rel16070869

Copyright: © 2025 by the author. Licensee MDPI, Basel, Switzerland. This article is an open access article distributed under the terms and conditions of the Creative Commons Attribution (CC BY) license (https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by/4.0/).

1. Introduction

The movement to decolonize South African higher education, ignited by campaigns such as #RhodesMustFall and #FeesMustFall, has reshaped academic discourse, challenging the dominance of Western epistemologies in university curricula (Magezi 2018; Mbembe 2015). Though public protests have subsided, the call for epistemic inclusivity persists in the scholarly literature, particularly in disciplines like theology, where Eurocentric frameworks have long overshadowed African perspectives (Harold 2022; Maluleke 1996, p. 8; Naidoo 2016, p. 1). Theological education in Africa often reflects this legacy, prioritizing Western doctrines and methodologies that frequently fail to resonate with African communities' spiritual, cultural, and social realities (Harold 2022, p. 1; Louw 2017, p. 3; Magezi 2018, p. 5; Nanthambwe 2024). This disconnect underscores a critical need to integrate African Indigenous Knowledge Systems (AIKS)—a range of oral traditions, communal spiritualities, cultural practices, and ethical principles like ubuntu—into theological discourse to foster more relevant and transformative engagement (Bujo 1992; Nyamnjoh 2017).

While current debates around decolonization have been reignited by student movements in the 21st century, the intellectual struggle for epistemic liberation in Africa predates these protests. Decolonization in the African theological context must be understood not merely as political emancipation but as a long-standing effort to reclaim indigenous ways of knowing that were suppressed during colonial and missionary rule. Historically, theological education in Africa was shaped by Western frameworks—doctrines, pedagogies, and worldviews introduced through European mission institutions—which often dismissed African spiritual systems as primitive or incompatible with Christian orthodoxy (Kalu 2003; Maluleke 1996). As a result, university theology today bears the marks of this legacy, privileging Eurocentric canons and methodologies. Decolonization therefore entails more than the inclusion of African content; it demands a fundamental rethinking of theological knowledge production. This article contributes to that broader project by engaging the integration of African Indigenous Knowledge Systems (AIKSs) within public theology as a strategic entry point for epistemic transformation in theological education.

AIKSs offer a holistic worldview that contrasts with Western theology's often individualistic and text-centric approaches (Chilisa 2019, p. 34; Harold 2022, p. 2). Rooted in communal wisdom, storytelling, and ecological interconnectedness, AIKSs hold untapped potential to enrich theological reflection and practice (Chilisa 2019). Their marginalization within academic theology reflects broader challenges of epistemic exclusion, necessitating deliberate strategies to center indigenous perspectives.

While decolonization is an imperative that cuts across all theological disciplines, such as biblical studies, systematic theology, practical theology, and missiology, this article focuses on public theology as a particularly fertile ground for engaging these questions. Public theology, with its commitment to addressing societal issues through dialog and ethical reflection, offers a compelling framework for integrating AIKSs. Unlike forms of theology that may remain confined to ecclesial or academic contexts, public theology engages with pressing public concerns such as social justice, reconciliation, and cultural identity. This positions it well to bridge AIKSs with the everyday experiences and struggles of African communities (Smit 2007; Cilliers 2015).

Integrating AIKSs into public theology promises a contextualized theological discourse that speaks directly to African realities while confronting the colonial legacies embedded in theological education (Lartey 2025, p. 91). As Lartey notes, much of African theological discourse remains framed by Western Christian paradigms, rendering it alien to African worldviews. However, realizing this integration is fraught with challenges, including institutional resistance, epistemological tensions, and the need for practical methodologies to embed indigenous knowledge into curricula and practice (Ndlovu-Gatsheni 2018).

This article addresses these complexities by asking the following question: how can public theology frame, articulate, and enhance the public function of African Indigenous Knowledge Systems (AIKSs) to foster more contextually grounded and transformative theological engagement in Africa? This framing acknowledges the enduring relevance and presence of AIKSs in African public life and seeks to explore how public theology can become a more effective vehicle for engaging, amplifying, and legitimizing these indigenous epistemologies within theological discourse and academic formation. Through this inquiry, this study contributes to the broader discourse on decolonizing theological education, proposing pathways for public theology, among other theological approaches, to catalyze social transformation and cultural affirmation. By foregrounding AIKSs, it envisions a theology that is not only academically robust but also deeply rooted in the lived experiences of African peoples.

2. African Indigenous Knowledge (AIK): Concepts and Significance

The concept of African Indigenous Knowledge (AIK) has garnered significant attention in academic and developmental discourse, yet its conceptualization remains fragmented. Higgs et al. (2003, p. 40) highlight the extensive literature on indigenous knowledge and development in Africa but note a lack of clear conceptual clarity. This raises the following question: why is AIK so challenging to define, and what makes it distinct?

African Indigenous Knowledge (AIK) is challenging to define due to its diverse, context-specific, and dynamic nature. Higgs et al. (2003, pp. 40–41) note the lack of conceptual clarity in the literature, stemming from several factors:

- Diversity across contexts: AIKSs vary significantly across African communities, shaped by unique cultural, ecological, and historical contexts. This diversity resists a universal definition as practices and knowledge systems differ between, for example, the Yoruba of Nigeria and the San of Southern Africa.
- Oral transmission: AIK is primarily transmitted orally through storytelling, proverbs, and rituals rather than written texts (Hoppers 2002). This fluidity makes it harder to codify and standardize compared to formalized knowledge systems like those in Western academia.
- Holistic and interdisciplinary nature: AIK integrates social, spiritual, ecological, and practical dimensions, defying the compartmentalized categories often used in Western epistemology (Dei 2002). This holistic approach complicates efforts to pin it down within conventional academic frameworks.
- Marginalization by colonial legacies: Colonialism and Western knowledge systems have historically marginalized AIK, labeling it as "informal" or "primitive." This has led to under documentation and a lack of frameworks to articulate its complexity, further obscuring its definition (Olaitan 2024).

This conceptual fragmentation is evident in the varying definitions and emphases found in the literature. For instance, in an official discourse, the South African Government (2004, p. 10) adopts a more pragmatic and policy-oriented elaboration:

> Indigenous knowledge (IK) is generally used synonymously with traditional and local knowledge to differentiate the knowledge developed by and within distinctive indigenous communities from the international knowledge system generated through universities, government research centres and private industry, sometimes incorrectly called the Western knowledge system.

In contrast, Dei (2002, p. 5) frames AIK's definition as a culturally situated epistemology grounded in spiritual, ecological, and social realities, offering a more ontological and relational interpretation, defining Indigenous knowledge as something that "encapsulates the common-good-sense ideas and cultural knowledge of local peoples concerning the everyday realities of living". He (Dei 2002) further clarifies that this traditional knowledge is part of the cultural heritage and histories of peoples. It specifically refers to the epistemic saliency of cultural traditions, values, belief systems, and worldviews that, in any indigenous society, are imparted to the younger generation by community elders and often transmitted orally. Such knowledge constitutes an "indigenous informed epistemology" (Dei 2002, p. 6). It is a worldview that shapes the community's relationships with the surrounding environment. It is the product of the direct experience of nature and its relationship with the social world. Indigenous knowledge is crucial for the survival of society. It is knowledge that is based on cognitive understandings and interpretations of the social, physical, and spiritual worlds. It includes concepts, beliefs, perceptions, and experiences of local people and their natural and human-built environments (Dei 2002, p. 6).

Furthermore, Hoppers (2002, p. 8) defines Indigenous Knowledge (IK) primarily in terms of oral traditions and communal knowledge, highlighting its philosophical and educational aspects. While indigenous knowledge is not exclusive to Africa and can be found in various forms across Asia, the Americas, and Europe, the focus on African Indigenous Knowledge (AIK) requires attention to its particular cultural and epistemological dimensions. As conceptualized by Hoppers (2002) and Dei (2002), three key characteristics define AIK. First, it represents a culturally rooted and community-oriented epistemology, grounded in the traditions, values, and worldviews of African societies and transmitted through intergenerational practices. Second, AIK is experiential and environmentally embedded, emerging from the lived realities and ecological interactions of local communities. Third, it is essential for the survival and continuity of society, offering a holistic understanding of reality that integrates the physical, social, and spiritual dimensions of life. These features distinguish AIK within the broader discourse on indigenous knowledge globally while also underscoring its relevance and contribution to knowledge production and sustainable development (Olaitan 2024).

Osman (2009) posits that African Indigenous Knowledge Systems (AIKSs) function across two interconnected dimensions: the empirical and the cognitive. The empirical dimension encompasses three primary domains: (i) natural, (ii) technological and architectural, and (iii) socio-cultural. The natural domain includes ecological systems, biodiversity, soil management, agricultural practices, and medicinal and pharmaceutical knowledge. The technological and architectural domain comprises various crafts, such as metallurgy, textile production, basketry, food processing, and construction. The socio-cultural domain encompasses aspects of social welfare, governance, conflict resolution, music, and art (Hoppers 2002, p. 3).

It is within this socio-cultural domain that AIKSs hold significant potential to influence the development of public theology in Africa. In this sense, Olaitan (2024) argues for the critical role of AIKs in fostering socio-economic development in Africa. She (Olaitan 2024) contends that AIKSs should not be viewed merely as an alternative to Western knowledge but as holistic systems encompassing knowledge, beliefs, practices, and values that can guide African life and development. Olaitan (2024, p. 1) states the following:

> . . .This growing interest is evident in the various initiatives undertaken within communities, where they are documenting their knowledge for integration into their educational systems and for strategic planning in national organisations. Understanding the contribution that AIKS can make to development requires the acknowledgement of its transformative impact beyond knowledge. This is also in consideration that AIKS has many benefits for improving governance, medicine, technology, entrepreneurship etc. The myopic view of AIKS as alternative knowledge will only restrict it to a knowledge system, whereas it has numerous useful practices that can be applied to the African context.

Despite AIK fragmentation, this article views the diversity within AIK not as a limitation but as an opportunity. By mapping out the conceptual range—from policy definitions to philosophical, empirical, and theological interpretations—the article synthesizes common features and proposes a more coherent and theologically relevant understanding of AIKSs. Hence, this article refers to African Indigenous Knowledge (AIK) as the holistic, community-based systems of knowing that are rooted in the cultural traditions, values, belief systems, and lived experiences of African societies. Transmitted primarily through oral traditions, rituals, and communal practices, AIKSs integrate spiritual, ecological, and social dimensions of life. It is a dynamic and context-specific epistemology that informs how communities understand reality, maintain social order, interact with their environment, and pursue well-being. While diverse in expression across different African contexts, AIK shares standard features of in-

tergenerational transmission, collective wisdom, and a holistic worldview, making it a vital resource for reimagining theological education and practice in Africa.

It is in this regard that AIK represents more than a repository of traditional wisdom; it is a dynamic, living epistemology capable of decolonizing theology, reframing development discourse, and empowering African communities to shape their future in ways that are both culturally authentic and spiritually grounded. Building on this understanding, the following section explores how AIK systems intersect with contemporary debates in public theology.

3. Public Theology and African Indigenous Knowledge Systems—Their Integration and Challenges

The integration of African Indigenous Knowledge Systems (AIKSs) into public theology is a pivotal endeavor to decolonize theological discourse and anchor it in the lived realities of African communities (Harold 2022; Lartey 2025). AIKSs, defined by their cultural rootedness, experiential foundation, and holistic integration of social, spiritual, and ecological dimensions (Dei 2002), offer a robust epistemological framework for public theology. This intersection is especially pertinent in contemporary African public spheres, where debates on identity, justice, ecology, and governance are paramount (Agang et al. 2020; Nche and Michael 2024). Below, we examine the significance of this integration, key themes in current debates, and its transformative implications for African societies.

3.1. Public Theology's Unique Place in Africa

In contrast to the secular modernism that characterizes much of Western society, where religion is relegated to the private sphere, African societies maintain a holistic integration of religion into all aspects of life (Adam and Boafo 2022; Mbiti 1991). Clarke and Jennings (2008) observe that Western socio-political structures often exclude religion, while in Africa, religion remains foundational, shaping ethical frameworks, social structures, and political decision-making. As Mbiti (1991, p. 1) famously stated, "Africans are notoriously religious," emphasizing how faith permeates every facet of life from birth to death. For this reason, Adam and Boafo retort, "It is imperative for Africans to do theology that relies on African anthropology or the African way of learning"; thus, African Indigenous Knowledge has to be promoted.

Religion in Africa is not a compartmentalized personal matter but a communal reality that anchors identity, cohesion, and moral order. Magesa (1997) underscores that the theoretical purpose of religion in African contexts is to foster social harmony, cultural continuity, and community well-being. Religious traditions—whether African Traditional Religions (ATRs), Christianity, or Islam—function as systems of guidance for leadership, conflict resolution, and societal governance. In this regard, Van Rooyen (2019) highlights the role of religion in shaping justice, leadership, and governance, particularly in South Africa, while Agbiji and Swart (2015) describe African life as a religious continuum marked by rituals from cradle to grave.

Kalu (2010) and Chitando et al. (2013) further argue that religion is central—often unconsciously so—to African identity. Religious beliefs and practices are woven into festivals, public rituals, and community life, legitimizing leadership and influencing collective decisions. As such, religion in Africa is not merely a cultural artifact but a lived, dynamic force that interacts with governance, economics, and social development.

In public life, the place of religion continues to generate debate. Scholars like Köhrsen (2012) critique expansive claims about religion's resurgence, particularly in Western contexts, cautioning against assuming all public expressions are genuinely religious. Yet in Africa, the integration of religion in public life is not an emerging trend but an enduring reality. As Igboin (2022) and Nanthambwe and Magezi (2024) note, the relevance

of religion in African public spaces stems from its ability to provide moral guidance, build social capital, and address pressing social challenges.

This backdrop makes public theology a particularly resonant framework in African societies. To frame this conversation more precisely, public theology in this article refers to critical theological reflection that intentionally engages issues of societal concern in public spaces—such as governance, justice, ethics, and development—while being rooted in both theological tradition and contemporary lived realities (Dreyer 2004; Smit 2007; Mannion 2009). Yet, as scholars like Chammah J. Kaunda (2016, 2019) have argued, it is crucial to decolonize public theology itself, recognizing how inherited Western theological frameworks often undermine or ignore African agency. Kaunda's critique of the instrumentalization of religion in Zambian political campaigns and his call for a decolonial theological turn offer important insights into how public theology can resist colonial epistemologies and affirm African knowledge systems. His work foregrounds the idea that African theology, by its very nature, has always been public—emerging from communal experiences, rituals, and struggles for liberation and social cohesion. Thus, this article aligns with and contributes to the growing body of African public theology by proposing African Indigenous Knowledge Systems (AIKSs) as a critical epistemic resource for deepening the decolonial turn in theological reflection and education.

Public theology in Africa thus finds fertile ground in a context where religion is already embedded in public consciousness. As Kim (2024) notes, public theology restores theology's public dimension by shaping community ethics and contributing to the formation of a political consensus. Smit (2007, 2017) reinforces this by outlining theology's role in engaging four distinct publics in South Africa: political, economic, civil society, and public opinion. The goal is to foster ethical governance, counter corruption, and promote justice.

The work of Agang et al. (2020) further demonstrates how African public theology offers constructive engagement with governance. Rooted in Christian values, it calls for accountability, transparency, and policy-oriented theological reflection. Religious leaders are encouraged to step beyond the pulpit and engage in democratic processes, advocating for the common good.

In this sense, public theology is not an imported framework imposed on African realities but a natural extension of Africa's integrated religious worldview. It affirms that faith has a legitimate and transformative role in public life, offering ethical resources for confronting social injustices and envisioning holistic development. As the next section will explore, this deeply embedded religious identity provides a strong foundation for reimagining Afrocentric governance models that incorporate religious values to effectively address contemporary challenges.

3.2. The Need for the Integration of African Indigenous Knowledge Systems into Public Theology

The fundamental question remains: why integrate AIKSs into public theology in Africa? The integration of AIKSs into public theology in Africa is a compelling proposition rooted in the need for contextual relevance and cultural resonance. Resane (2022) argues that theology in Africa must align with the communal epistemologies of African societies, where knowledge is shared collectively rather than individualized. This perspective highlights the significance of AIKSs, which encompasses indigenous ways of knowing, including oral traditions, communal practices, and spiritual frameworks, as a vital resource for making theology more accessible and impactful (Resane 2022, p. 2). It challenges Western methodical theologizing by prioritizing and reframing the praxis story and proverbial expressions to facilitate a critical reevaluation of Western Christian thought, which tends to marginalize African experiences. For Africans, religion is "an experienced

reality" (Mugambi 1974, p. 54); therefore, it should be culturally appealing and relevant (Adam and Boafo 2022).

It is important to acknowledge, however, that the integration of AIKSs into public theology is not entirely absent. Pioneering figures such as Desmond Tutu have made significant strides in this direction, most notably through the development of Ubuntu theology, which draws deeply from African communal values and moral frameworks. Ubuntu theology exemplifies how African Indigenous values, such as relationality, dignity, and interconnectedness, can serve as theological resources for addressing public concerns, including reconciliation, justice, and human rights. These contributions demonstrate that there are significant precedents for integrating AIK within theological discourse and that public theology in Africa is already influenced, in part, by indigenous sensibilities.

Nonetheless, such efforts—while foundational and significant—remain underutilized and uneven across institutions and theological frameworks. Much of African theology still operates within paradigms shaped by colonial mission legacies, which often ignore or suppress local ways of knowing and being (Sakupapa 2017, 2018). This intellectual and theological dependency perpetuates epistemic injustice, where AIK is regarded as primitive, irrational, or untheological. To integrate AIKSs meaningfully, public theology must therefore commit to epistemic decolonization—a deliberate process of recovering, revaluing, and re-centering African epistemologies in theological discourse. This involves not merely adding indigenous elements to Western frameworks but reconstructing theological foundations to reflect African worldviews, languages, and spiritual insights. As scholars like Ramose (2002) and Higgs (2012) argue, African philosophy and indigenous knowledge systems possess their own logic, coherence, and depth, which should not be subordinated to foreign categories. Higgs (2012, p. 37) laments:

> The marginalisation of African values in African education has resulted in the general Westernisation of education theory and practice in Africa, and educational research has not escaped this process. Dominant research epistemologies have developed methods of initiating and assessing research in Africa where researchers fail to acknowledge the cultural preferences and practices of African people. Instead, research epistemologies and methods are located within the cultural preferences and practices of the Western world. Such practices have perpetuated an ideology of cultural superiority that precludes the development of power-sharing processes and the legitimisation of diverse cultural epistemologies and cosmologies.

Moreover, decolonizing African knowledge also challenges theological education and formation to break free from inherited Eurocentric curricula (Kalu 2003; Magezi 2018; Sakupapa 2017, 2018). It calls for the creation of spaces where African voices, symbols, and experiences become primary theological sources, not just contextual add-ons (Mugambi 2013). Mugambi (2013, p. 118) notes the following:

> There is nothing specifically African in the doctrines recited by African branches of various denominations—such as the Anglican, Baptist, Congregationalist, Lutheran, Mennonite, Methodist, Moravian, Orthodox, Pentecostal, Presbyterian, Quaker, Reformed and Roman Catholic denominations. Yet in practice African Christians in these denominations remain rooted in their respective African cultural traditions. For them Christianity remains largely a Sunday affair, with little or no direct impact on the political, economic, ethical, and aesthetic norms of wider society.

In this regard, the integration of AIKSs becomes both a theological and a political act, restoring dignity to African peoples and affirming their agency in shaping theology that speaks to their realities.

Public theology, with its concern for justice, human dignity, and the common good, is well-positioned to champion this decolonial turn. It can act as a platform through which the church and academy critique inherited colonial theologies and cultivate Afrocentric frameworks that resonate with the moral, social, and spiritual aspirations of African communities. Through dialog with AIKSs, public theology in Africa can become more rooted, responsive, and revolutionary, capable of addressing the continent's challenges from within its own cultural and epistemological soil.

The integration of AIKSs into public theology is not only about cultural relevance—it is an urgent task of epistemic justice. It is about reclaiming African voices, reshaping theological discourse, and resisting intellectual colonization. In doing so, public theology can offer more faithful and liberating responses to the needs of African societies today.

3.3. Challenges in Integrating African Indigenous Knowledge Systems into Public Theology

The integration of African Indigenous Knowledge Systems (AIKSs) into public theology presents a transformative opportunity for contextual theological engagement. However, this process is fraught with numerous challenges that span epistemological, institutional, and practical dimensions. These barriers not only hinder the inclusion of AIKSs in theological education but also perpetuate colonial knowledge hierarchies that marginalize African epistemologies.

3.3.1. Epistemological Conflicts

One of the primary and enduring challenges in integrating African Indigenous Knowledge Systems (AIKSs) into public theology is the deep epistemological tension between AIKSs and dominant Western theological frameworks. AIKSs are fundamentally rooted in oral tradition, communal wisdom, and experiential spirituality. They value lived experience, interdependence, and symbolic forms of knowledge transmission such as storytelling, proverbs, ritual practices, and song. In contrast, Western theology has historically privileged textual, individualistic, and rationalist approaches, emphasizing systematic doctrine, propositional truths, and abstract reasoning. These divergent epistemic foundations often lead to misunderstandings, marginalization, or the outright rejection of AIKSs within formal theological education.

Balcomb (2015, pp. 3–4) vividly captures the alienating effects of this disjunction, observing that "a Western theological education, far from equipping African graduates for ministry back home, alienates them from their faith, their context, and their people". His critique highlights how the imposition of a Western theological paradigm not only fails to resonate with the socio-cultural realities of African communities but also severs graduates from the spiritual and communal resources necessary for contextual ministry. This epistemological alienation reflects a broader pattern of exclusion and domination that has shaped African education since colonial times.

Ndlovu-Gatsheni (2018) takes this analysis further by describing the dominance of Western epistemologies in African higher education as a form of epistemic violence. This term refers to the systematic delegitimization and erasure of indigenous ways of knowing, which are often dismissed as unscientific, irrational, or anecdotal. He argues that this hegemony continues to silence African voices in academic and theological discourse, effectively reproducing colonial patterns of knowledge control under the guise of universalism. In theological education, this results in the privileging of Euro-American theological constructs while marginalizing African spiritualities and cosmologies, even within African institutions.

Addressing these epistemological conflicts requires a fundamental shift toward epistemic pluralism—a pedagogical and philosophical orientation that affirms the coexistence and co-legitimacy of multiple knowledge systems. This approach rejects the hierarchical classification of knowledge and instead values the theological insights embedded in indigenous cultures, languages, and practices. AIKSs must be understood not as supplementary or folkloric, but as a legitimate and autonomous source of theological reflection and public engagement (Olaitan 2024; Osman 2009).

Ndlovu-Gatsheni (2018, p. 5) frames this imperative as the pursuit of epistemic freedom, which involves the decolonization of knowledge systems and the recognition that knowledge cannot be confined to "philosophical" or "scientific" forms alone. He insists that true decolonization requires the acknowledgment and incorporation of diverse ways of knowing, including oral, performative, and community-based epistemologies. In the context of public theology, this means developing pedagogies and theological frameworks that are deeply informed by African Indigenous Knowledge Systems (AIKSs), allowing African communities to engage their faith in ways that are authentic, liberative, and contextually relevant.

Therefore, overcoming these epistemological tensions is not simply a matter of curriculum reform but a transformative process that requires theological institutions to rethink their foundational assumptions about knowledge, truth, and authority. It involves creating spaces where African voices, experiences, and wisdom traditions are not merely included but centered in the formation of theological thought and practice.

3.3.2. Institutional Barriers

At an institutional level, universities and theological seminaries remain deeply embedded in Eurocentric curricula that continue to privilege Western theological traditions (Naidoo 2016, p. 1). This entrenched orientation is the legacy of colonial and missionary education systems that positioned Western epistemologies as universal and normative while marginalizing or dismissing African Indigenous Knowledge Systems (AIKSs) as primitive or irrelevant. Despite ongoing calls for transformation and decolonization, institutional resistance to integrating indigenous knowledge remains pervasive.

Higgs (2012) and Naidoo (2016) contend that efforts at educational reform have often been superficial or symbolic, with academic institutions retaining colonial structures that perpetuate exclusionary knowledge hierarchies. These structures are sustained through various mechanisms, including accreditation standards, faculty training models, research agendas, and prescribed textbook content—all of which tend to reflect and reproduce a Western intellectual canon. As a result, theological curricula frequently overlook or undervalue AIKSs, making it difficult for African theological education to engage authentically with local cultural and spiritual realities.

Letsekha (2013, p. 8) illustrates this tension within the South African context, observing that while some institutions of higher learning have made commendable strides in contextualizing their pedagogical frameworks, many curricula still favor Western modes of knowledge production. This is particularly paradoxical given the post-apartheid constitutional framework, which promotes the recognition and development of indigenous knowledge systems as part of the broader project of educational and cultural transformation. However, institutional inertia, coupled with a lack of political will and inadequate policy implementation, has hindered meaningful change.

Theological education therefore remains largely disconnected from the lived experiences of African communities. It fails to adequately equip students to engage with indigenous epistemologies and communal practices that shape the spiritual, moral, and social fabric of African societies (Balcomb 2015). This disconnect reinforces an intellectual

dependency on foreign frameworks and undermines the capacity of theological education to contribute effectively to the continent's decolonial and developmental needs.

3.3.3. Practical Challenges

Practical issues further complicate the integration of African Indigenous Knowledge Systems (AIKSs) into public theology. A significant barrier is the absence of systematic documentation and codification of AIKSs. Unlike Western theological frameworks, which are predominantly text-based and extensively archived, AIKSs primarily exist within oral traditions, symbolic expressions, ritual practices, proverbs, and lived communal experiences (Naidoo 2016). This makes them challenging to engage with using conventional academic methods, which often prioritize written texts, formal logic, and structured argumentation.

It is important to acknowledge that not all theological institutions entirely exclude African Indigenous Knowledge Systems (AIKSs). In many contexts, particularly where theology is taught alongside or in conjunction with religious studies, elements of African Traditional Religion (ATR) and indigenous worldviews are introduced to students. Some faculties also engage in interdisciplinary collaboration with departments such as anthropology, philosophy, or cultural studies to offer broader perspectives. However, despite these important efforts, AIKSs often remain peripheral to core theological curricula. They are frequently treated as a comparative or supplementary subject rather than being integrated as a foundational epistemological framework. The concern, therefore, is not that AIKSs are universally absent but that their inclusion is uneven, fragmented, and often lacks systematic theological engagement. This article thus calls for a more intentional and integrative approach that recognizes the AIKS not merely as cultural background but as a valid theological resource in its own right. Consequently, theological education frequently overlooks or undervalues indigenous sources of knowledge, reinforcing epistemological hierarchies and excluding vital aspects of African spiritual and cultural life (Balcomb 2015; Ndlovu-Gatsheni 2018; Naidoo 2016). Missionary education systems—closely aligned with colonial governance—played a pivotal role in shaping theological education by introducing Western epistemologies that framed African spiritual systems as inferior or unworthy of theological consideration (Maluleke 1996; Kalu 2003). These institutions established a legacy in which theology and religious studies were dominated by imported categories, languages, and curricula that alienated African learners from their own contexts. As a result, the academic study of theology in many African universities continues to operate within frameworks that reflect and reinforce colonial knowledge hierarchies.

Training theologians in AIKSs therefore demands more than the inclusion of content; it necessitates a comprehensive pedagogical reorientation. This includes developing methodologies that can engage oral histories, performative acts, intergenerational storytelling, indigenous hermeneutics, and the communal nature of African spirituality. Such an approach challenges dominant academic norms, calling for theologians to adopt more holistic, participatory, and interdisciplinary strategies in both teaching and research.

Mercy Amba Oduyoye (1995), a pioneering voice in African women's theology, has consistently emphasized the importance of drawing upon indigenous cultural narratives and gendered experiences as legitimate theological resources. Her work has shown how African women's everyday experiences—often transmitted through oral traditions, folklore, songs, and communal wisdom—are rich with theological meaning. She insists that these experiences must not be sidelined but should inform the way theology is taught and practiced in African contexts. As she poignantly states, "African women's theology must arise out of what we know best—our stories, songs, and struggles. These are the texts from which we theologize" (Oduyoye 1995, p. 10).

This insight underscores the importance of designing theological training programs that are inclusive, contextually grounded, and responsive to the diverse nature of knowledge in African societies. It also highlights the importance of mentoring theologians who can move fluidly between the academy and the community, people who are not only well-versed in theological theory but also equipped to interpret and engage with the spiritual, cultural, and ethical knowledge embedded in local practices. Without such a shift, theological education risks remaining elitist and detached from the lived realities of the very communities it seeks to serve.

Ultimately, addressing these practical challenges requires a commitment to epistemic justice at the institutional level. This includes revising accreditation criteria, funding research on indigenous theologies, training faculty in indigenous pedagogies, and creating collaborative spaces where academic and community voices can co-construct theological knowledge. By embracing the richness of AIKSs through innovative, inclusive methodologies, theological education can become a transformative force that affirms African identity and empowers communities in meaningful and contextually relevant ways.

Which strategies could be employed to make this integration a reality? The following section outlines key approaches and practical steps that can facilitate the successful implementation of this integration.

4. Strategies for Integrating AIKSs into Public Theology

Efforts to integrate African Indigenous Knowledge Systems (AIKSs) into public theology must be guided by deliberate, contextually grounded strategies that challenge epistemic hierarchies while affirming the richness and relevance of indigenous epistemologies. A meaningful decolonial project must therefore move beyond surface inclusion of African content to engage critically with the deep structural and epistemological imprint left by colonialism. This article contributes to that ongoing intellectual project by interrogating how public theology—understood as theology that engages societal concerns—can serve as a pathway for re-integrating African Indigenous Knowledge Systems (AIKSs) into theological discourse and practice. The following strategies provide a framework for a more inclusive and transformative theological praxis.

First is epistemological reorientation and recognition of African Indigenous Knowledge Systems (AIKSs). A critical first step in integrating AIKSs into theological and developmental discourse involves the formal recognition of AIK as a legitimate, autonomous, and contextually rooted system of knowledge (Olaitan 2024; Kaya and Seleti 2013; South African Government 2004). Historically, AIKSs have been marginalized or dismissed as inferior to Western epistemologies, a legacy of colonialism that continues to shape institutional knowledge structures. As Ndlovu-Gatsheni (2018) asserts, achieving epistemic freedom requires a radical departure from the entrenched dominance of Euro-American philosophical and scientific paradigms. This entails embracing pluriverse ways of knowing that include oral traditions, symbolic systems, myths, spiritualities, and ritual-based knowledge forms that are foundational to many African communities.

Such an epistemological shift challenges the assumption that Western theology holds a monopoly on valid knowledge production. Instead, it recognizes that AIKSs offer rich and contextually relevant theological insights capable of informing both academic and grassroots practices. Kaya and Seleti (2013, p. 31) emphasize that this reorientation must be led by African scholars who articulate an indigenous conception of knowledge grounded in Africa's intellectual history and lived experiences. This involves recovering and valorizing African intellectual traditions, not simply as cultural artifacts but as dynamic and evolving frameworks capable of engaging with contemporary theological and developmental challenges.

Furthermore, policy frameworks, such as the South African Indigenous Knowledge Systems (IKSs) Policy (South African Government 2004), support this reorientation by calling for the integration of indigenous knowledge into formal education and research. Olaitan (2024) also underscores the urgency of this shift, particularly in light of the increasing recognition of the role AIKSs can play in sustainable development, social cohesion, and theological innovation. Recognizing AIKSs as a valid epistemological source is not merely a symbolic gesture but a foundational move toward a more inclusive, contextually grounded, and transformative knowledge landscape.

The second step is curriculum transformation and decolonization. Curriculum development must be reimagined to reflect the epistemic diversity of African societies and to challenge the enduring influence of colonial knowledge systems. Higgs (2012) and Naidoo (2016) highlight that African educational institutions, including theological seminaries, remain shaped mainly by Eurocentric frameworks that continue to marginalize indigenous voices and ways of knowing. This inherited imbalance limits the relevance and transformative potential of theological education on the continent.

To address this, theological curricula should intentionally incorporate African cosmologies, ethical systems, spiritual practices, and indigenous hermeneutics (Naidoo 2024; Maluleke 1996). Naidoo (2024) discusses the imperative for African theological education to be responsive to the continent's socio-political and economic contexts. She emphasizes the need for curriculum design that focuses on African realities and prepares students for ethical leadership and transformative engagement in society. Such inclusion is not merely additive but foundational, affirming the theological significance of African worldviews. This means rethinking course content, reading materials, and pedagogical methods to ensure they reflect African intellectual traditions and the lived realities of African communities (Sakupapa 2018).

As Oduyoye (1995) insists, theology must "speak to the life that we live," grounding itself in the daily experiences, cultural narratives, and spiritual insights of African people. A decolonized curriculum should therefore empower students to engage theologically with their contexts, drawing on both faith and indigenous knowledge to address local challenges and contribute meaningfully to society.

The third step is community-based theological formation. Public theology should not be confined to academic or ecclesiastical institutions alone; instead, it must be rooted in the lived experiences, wisdom, and practices of African communities (Dreyer 2004; Magezi 2018; Mannion 2009). Theology that is disconnected from the everyday struggles and aspirations of ordinary people risks becoming abstract and irrelevant. Community-based theological formation calls for a shift from top-down, institutional models to participatory, grassroots engagements where theology is both formed and practiced within the rhythms of communal life.

This approach involves recognizing and integrating oral histories, local rituals, storytelling traditions, proverbs, and indigenous forms of pastoral care into theological training and reflection (Resane 2022). For instance, initiation rites and communal conflict resolution practices all hold implicit theological meanings that can enrich pastoral theology and ethics when correctly interpreted. Such practices offer insights into African cosmologies, notions of personhood, and communal well-being—concepts that are often underrepresented in conventional curricula.

Oduyoye (1995) emphasizes the theological significance of community narratives, particularly those of women, whose experiences are often shared informally through songs, storytelling, and communal gatherings rather than formal academic settings. For example, women's participation in community health initiatives, burial societies, or faith-based advocacy work reveals embodied theological insights on care, justice, and resilience.

Establishing platforms for theological dialog within communities, such as local forums, storytelling circles, or oral theology workshops, allows for reciprocal learning between trained theologians and community members. This fosters contextual authenticity, allowing theology to emerge not just from books and lecture halls but from the heartbeat of communal life. It also equips future church leaders and scholars to serve more effectively within their own cultural and spiritual landscapes, thereby reinforcing theology as a lived and living discipline.

The fourth step is faculty training and pedagogical innovation. For African Indigenous Knowledge Systems (AIKSs) to be effectively integrated into theological education, it is essential that theological educators themselves are equipped to teach using culturally responsive pedagogies. This requires rethinking both the content and the methods of instruction. Educators trained exclusively within Western epistemological frameworks often lack the tools to engage meaningfully with African worldviews and indigenous practices. Letsekha (2013) critiques this imbalance, stating that "despite the socio-political changes in post-apartheid South Africa, the dominant epistemological orientation in education remains Eurocentric," thereby reinforcing "the marginal status of African Indigenous Knowledge Systems" (Letsekha 2013, p. 5).

Faculty development programs must therefore prioritize epistemic reorientation. Such programs should train educators to incorporate oral traditions, performance, storytelling, rituals, and other embodied forms of knowledge into their teaching. Letsekha (2013) calls for "a deliberate effort to deconstruct dominant Western paradigms and reconstruct educational approaches that are inclusive of Africa's intellectual heritage" (p. 6). This implies a dual process of unlearning and re-learning: dismantling the unconscious biases embedded in Eurocentric education and learning to appreciate, validate, and communicate indigenous theological insights.

Supporting this view, Kabongo (2020) advocates for hybrid epistemologies that combine both African and Western knowledge systems in the theological classroom. He argues that embracing epistemological hybridity allows theological education to be more contextually grounded and relevant to African realities. This hybridity necessitates pedagogical innovation, utilizing case-based learning, experiential learning in community settings, and participatory methods that value local wisdom as a form of theological data.

Naidoo (2024) similarly highlights that theological education in Africa must be oriented toward social transformation and contextual relevance. She asserts that "theological curriculum should equip students to engage with the real socio-political and economic issues facing the continent, through the lens of African values and spiritual traditions." In this light, pedagogical innovation is not merely a matter of style but a justice issue: it ensures that education serves the needs and voices of historically marginalized communities.

Mkwebane (2024), though writing within the field of science education, provides valuable insights into practical strategies for cultural responsiveness that apply equally well to theology. She (Mkwebane 2024, p. 4) advocates for dialogic teaching, storytelling, and the use of indigenous communicative forms, such as songs and folktales, as methods that affirm students' identities and enhance engagement. Theological educators can adopt similar strategies to facilitate deeper student engagement with both theological content and local cultural and religious expressions.

Investing in faculty reorientation and pedagogical innovation enables institutions to transform theological education into a more inclusive, reflexive, and context-sensitive enterprise. In doing so, they empower students and communities alike to see African Indigenous Knowledge not as peripheral but as a vital source of theological wisdom and moral imagination.

The fifth step involves institutional reforms and policy advocacy. To meaningfully integrate African Indigenous Knowledge Systems (AIKSs) into theological education, comprehensive institutional reforms are imperative. This entails revising accreditation standards, diversifying reading lists, supporting research in indigenous theologies, and funding community engagement initiatives. Ndlovu-Gatsheni (2018) emphasizes the necessity of dismantling the "coloniality of knowledge" embedded in higher education structures, advocating for a reorientation that centers African epistemologies.

Recent scholarship underscores the urgency of these reforms. Kumalo (2023) argues that achieving epistemic justice in South African higher education requires "decentring canonical knowledge" and fostering "inter-epistemic dialogue" that values indigenous perspectives alongside Western paradigms. He posits that such an approach can transform universities into spaces that genuinely reflect and serve African societies.

Furthermore, Heleta and Dilraj (2024) critique the superficial adoption of decolonization rhetoric in South African universities, noting that despite student-led movements like #RhodesMustFall, many institutions remain entrenched in Eurocentric ideologies. He calls for a genuine commitment to epistemic decolonization that challenges and reimagines the power and knowledge matrix in higher education.

Incorporating AIK into theological education also involves embracing indigenous philosophies such as Ubuntu. Ngubane and Makua (2021) advocate for Ubuntu pedagogy as a transformative approach that promotes social justice, inclusivity, and respect for African values in higher education. By integrating Ubuntu principles, institutions can create learning environments that resonate with the lived experiences of African students.

Policy advocacy plays a crucial role in institutionalizing these reforms. Public theologians and academic leaders must engage with policymakers to develop frameworks that support the inclusion of AIKSs in curricula, research agendas, and institutional practices. This includes advocating for funding models that prioritize community-based research and the development of resources that reflect indigenous theological perspectives.

Eventually, these reforms aim to create an educational landscape where AIKSs are not merely an addendum but a foundational component of theological inquiry. Institutionalizing epistemic justice, theological education can become more reflective of and responsive to the diverse cultural and spiritual realities of African communities.

5. Concluding Remarks and Implications

This article has explored the conceptual foundations, significance, and integration of African Indigenous Knowledge Systems (AIKSs) into public theology, with particular emphasis on the South African context. It has been argued that the enduring dominance of Western epistemologies in theological education continues to alienate theology from the lived realities of African communities. Despite the relative quieting of decolonial discourse in mainstream academic conversations, the imperative to decolonize theological education remains urgent, especially given the marginalization of AIKSs within dominant curricular structures.

Through an analysis of epistemological, institutional, and practical barriers, this study has illuminated the deep-rooted challenges that hinder the integration of AIKSs into theological education. However, it has also demonstrated that these challenges are not insurmountable. Drawing on scholars such as Ndlovu-Gatsheni (2018), Higgs (2012), Naidoo (2016), and Oduyoye (1995), the article has outlined strategic interventions, including epistemological reorientation, curriculum transformation, and community-based theological formation. These strategies affirm AIKSs as a legitimate and autonomous theological resource capable of enriching theological discourse and training.

Importantly, public theology emerges as a viable and transformative avenue for integrating AIKSs. Its inherently dialogical and context-sensitive nature positions it as a dynamic platform for re-engaging theology with African socio-cultural and spiritual realities. Public theology's concern with justice, reconciliation, and the common good (De Gruchy 2002) aligns well with the values embedded in AIKSs, making it an effective catalyst for social transformation and inclusive development. By incorporating indigenous spiritualities, oral narratives, rituals, and community practices, public theology can speak more powerfully to issues such as poverty, inequality, gender justice, and identity formation—areas often sidelined in academic theology shaped by Western paradigms.

The integration of AIKSs into public theology is therefore not only an academic necessity but also a contextual and moral one. As Martey (2009) affirms, African theology must be both liberative and enculturated, responding to the concrete historical and cultural experiences of African peoples. This article contends that AIKSs, as a reservoir of communal wisdom and spiritual insight, have the potential to ground theological education in Africa's diverse and complex contexts.

Looking ahead, future research should explore regionally specific expressions of AIKSs and how these can inform theological curricula and ministerial formation across various African contexts. More attention is also needed on the methodological tools required to engage the oral, symbolic, and performative dimensions of indigenous knowledge in academic theology. Additionally, interdisciplinary collaboration—particularly with African philosophy, history, and cultural anthropology—can deepen the theoretical frameworks underpinning AIKSs in public theology.

In conclusion, integrating AIKSs into public theology promises not only to decolonize theological education but also to revitalize its relevance, rootedness, and prophetic capacity in Africa. This transformative vision challenges theological institutions, scholars, and practitioners to embrace a theology that is truly of, with, and for the people, reflecting the spiritual, cultural, and social aspirations of African communities.

Funding: This research received no extra funding.

Institutional Review Board Statement: Not applicable.

Informed Consent Statement: Not applicable.

Data Availability Statement: No new data were created or analyzed in this study.

Conflicts of Interest: The authors declare no conflict of interest.

References

Adam, Konadu, and Collins Boafo. 2022. A Reflection on African Christian Theology. *E-Journal of Religious and Theological Studies (ERATS)* 8: 280–86. [CrossRef]

Agang, Sunday B., Jurgens Hendriks, and Dion A. Forster, eds. 2020. *African Public Theology*. Bukuru: Hippo Books.

Agbiji, Obaji M., and Ignatius Swart. 2015. Religion and social transformation in Africa: A critical and appreciative perspective. *Scriptura* 114: 1–20. [CrossRef]

Balcomb, Anthony O. 2015. Theological Education in South Africa and the Epistemological Divide: In Search of the African Habitus. *Scriptura* 114: 1–12. [CrossRef]

Bujo, Bénézet. 1992. *African Theology in Its Social Context*. Nairobi: St. Paul Publications Africa.

Chilisa, Bagele. 2019. *Indigenous Research Methodologies*. Los Angeles: SAGE Publications.

Chitando, Ezra, Afe Adogame, and Bolaji Bateye. 2013. Introduction: African traditions in the study of religion in Africa: Contending with gender, the vitality of indigenous religions, and diaspora. In *African Traditions in the Study of Religion, Diaspora and Gendered Societies*. Edited by Afe Adogame, Ezra Chitando and Bolaji Bateye. Farnham: Ashgate, pp. 1–12.

Cilliers, Johan. 2015. Where have all the prophets gone? Perspectives on political preaching. *Stellenbosch Theological Journal* 1: 367–83. [CrossRef]

Clarke, Gerard, and Michael Jennings. 2008. Introduction. In *Development, Civil Society and Faith-based Organizations: Bridging the Sacred and the Secular*. Edited by Gerard Clarke and Michael Jennings. Palgrave Basingstoke: MacMillan, pp. 1–16.

De Gruchy, John W. 2002. *Reconciliation: Restoring Justice*. Minnesota: Fortress Press.

Dei, George J. Sefa. 2002. Rethinking the Role of Indigenous Knowledges in the Academy. *Nall Working Paper*, 58. Available online: https://files.eric.ed.gov/fulltext/ED479137.pdf (accessed on 16 April 2025).

Dreyer, Yolanda. 2004. A public practical theological theory for religious education of secularised youth. *HTS Teologiese Studies/Theological Studies* 60: 919–45. [CrossRef]

Harold, Godfrey. 2022. Developing an African Evangelical Theology. *Pharos Journal of Theology* 103: 1–11. [CrossRef]

Heleta, Savo, and Isha Dilraj. 2024. Decolonisation is not even a footnote: On the dominant ideologies and smokescreens in South African higher education. *Transformation in Higher Education* 9: a416. [CrossRef]

Higgs, Philip. 2012. African Philosophy and the Decolonisation of Education in Africa: Some Critical Reflections. *Educational Philosophy and Theory 44 S* 2: 37–55. [CrossRef]

Higgs, Philip, Leonie G. Higgs, and E. Venter. 2003. Indigenous African Knowledge Systems and Innovation in Higher Education System. *South African Journal of Higher Education* 17: 40–45.

Hoppers, Catherine A.O., ed. 2002. *Indigenous Knowledge and the Integration of Knowledge Systems: Towards a Philosophy of Articulation*. Claremont: New Africa Books.

Igboin, Benson O. 2022. The scramble for religion and secularism in Pre-Colonial Africa. *Religions* 13: 1096. [CrossRef]

Kabongo, Kasebwe T. L. 2020. Africanisation of theological education: An exploration of a hybrid epistemology. *HTS Teologiese Studies/Theological Studies* 76: a5911. [CrossRef]

Kalu, Ogbu U. 2003. Passive revolution and its saboteurs: African Christian Initiative in the era of decolonization, 1955–1975. In *Missions, Nationalism and the End of Empire*. Edited by B. Stanley. Grand Rapids: WB Eerdmans, pp. 250–77.

Kalu, Ogbu U. 2010. Faith and politics in Africa: Emergent political theology of engagement in Nigeria. In *Religions in Africa: Conflicts, Politics and Social Ethics*. Edited by Wilhelmina Kalu, Nimi Wariboko and Toyin Falola. Trenton: Africa World Press, pp. 11–30.

Kaunda, Chammah J. 2016. Towards an African Ecogender Theology: A Decolonial Theological Perspective. *Stellenbosch Theological Journal* 2: 177–202. [CrossRef]

Kaunda, Chammah J. 2019. Baptising Zambia's Edgar Chagwa Lungu': Critiquing the Utilization of the Declaration of Zambia during the Presidential Campaign of 2016. *International Journal of Public Theology* 13: 72–93. [CrossRef]

Kaya, Hassan O., and Yonah N. Seleti. 2013. African Indigenous Knowledge Systems and Relevance of Higher Education in South Africa. *The International Education Journal: Comparative Perspectives* 12: 30–44.

Kim, Seung-Hwan. 2024. The Public Role of Religion and the Response of Public Theology. *Religions* 15: 449. [CrossRef]

Köhrsen, Jens. 2012. How religious is the public sphere? A critical stance on the debate about public religion and post-secularity. *Acta Sociologica* 55: 273–88.

Kumalo, Siseko H. 2023. Developing epistemic impartiality to deliver on justice in higher education South Africa. *Education, Citizenship and Social Justice* 18: 85–97. [CrossRef]

Lartey, Emmanuel Y. 2025. Spiritual Care from the Perspective of Pastoral Theology: Postcolonial Views. In *What Is Spiritual Care?: Perspectives from Different Professions and Religious Traditions*. Edited by Claudia K. Reichenbach and Emmanuel Y. Lartey. Eugene: Pickwick Publications, pp. 91–96.

Letsekha, Tebello. 2013. Revisiting the debate on the Africanisation of higher education: An appeal for a conceptual shift. *The Independent Journal of Teaching and Learning* 8: 5–7.

Louw, Daniel J. 2017. "Black pain is a white commodity": Moving beyond postcolonial theory in practical theology: #CaesarMustFall. *HTS Teologiese Studies/Theological Studies* 73: a4504. [CrossRef]

Magesa, Laurenti. 1997. *African Religion: The Moral Traditions of Abundant Life*. Maryknoll: Orbis Books.

Magezi, Vhumani. 2018. A public practical-theological response and proposal to decolonisation discourse in South Africa: From #YourStatueMustFall and #MyStatueShouldBeErected to #BothOurStatues ShouldBeErected. *HTS Teologiese Studies/Theological Studies* 74: 5030. [CrossRef]

Maluleke, Tinyiko S. 1996. Black and African Theologies in the New World Order: A Time to Drink from Our Own Wells. *Journal of Theology for Southern Africa* 96: 3–19.

Mannion, Gerard. 2009. A Brief Genealogy of Public Theology, or Doing Theology When It Seems Nobody Is Listening. *Annali di Studi Religiosi* 10: 121–54. Available online: https://books.fbk.eu/media/pubblicazioni/allegati/Mannion_121-152.pdf (accessed on 16 May 2025).

Martey, Emmanuel. 2009. *African Theology: Inculturation and Liberation*. Eugene: Wipf & Stock Publishers.

Mbembe, Achille. 2015. Decolonizing Knowledge and the Question of the Archive. *Wits Institute for Social and Economic Research (WISER)*. Available online: https://wiser.wits.ac.za/system/files/Achille%20Mbembe%20-%20Decolonizing%20Knowledge%20and%20the%20Question%20of%20the%20Archive.pdf (accessed on 14 April 2025).

Mbiti, John S. 1991. *Introduction to African Religion*. London: Heinemann.

Mkwebane, Lwazi K. 2024. Life Science Teachers' Integration of Indigenous Knowledge: A Vision for Making Science Classromms Culturally Responsive. *EURASIA Journal of Mathematics, Science and Technology Education* 20: 1–12. [CrossRef]
Mugambi, Jesse. 1974. *Carry it Home*. Nairobi: EA Literature Bureau.
Mugambi, Jesse. 2013. The future of theological education in Africa and the challenges it faces. In *Handbook of Theological Education in Africa*. Edited by Isabelo A. Phiri and Dietrich Werner. Oxford: Regnum Books, pp. 117–25.
Naidoo, Marilyn. 2016. Overcoming alienation in Africanising theological education. *HTS Theological Studies* 72: 1–8. [CrossRef]
Naidoo, Marilyn. 2024. African Theological Education and the Need for Curriculum Responsiveness to African Union's Agenda 2063. *Acta Theologica* 44: 221–37. [CrossRef]
Nanthambwe, Patrick. 2024. Why is pastoral care crucial to Africa? Towards an African pastoral care perspective. *Theologia Viatorum* 48: a228. [CrossRef]
Nanthambwe, Patrick, and Vhumani Magezi. 2024. The African pastor as a public figure in response to Gender-Based Violence in South Africa: A public pastoral intervention. *Religions* 15: 609. [CrossRef]
Nche, George C., and Benson O. Michael. 2024. Perspectives on African Indigenous Religion and the Natural Environment: Beings, Interconnectedness, Communities and Knowledge Systems. *Phronimon* 25: 1–26. [CrossRef]
Ndlovu-Gatsheni, Sabelo J. 2018. *Epistemic Freedom in Africa: Deprovincialization and Decolonization*. London: Routledge.
Ngubane, Nomalungelo I., and Manyane Makua. 2021. Intersection of *Ubuntu* pedagogy and social justice: Transforming South African higher education. *Transformation in Higher Education* 6: a113. [CrossRef]
Nyamnjoh, Francis B. 2017. *Drinking from the Cosmic Gourd: How Amos Tutuola Can Change Our Minds*. Bamenda: Langaa RPCIG.
Oduyoye, Mercy A. 1995. *Daughters of Anowa: African Women and Partiarchy*. Maryknoll: Orbis Books.
Olaitan, Zainab M. 2024. *The Relevance of African Indigenous Knowledge Systems for Development in Africa*. Policy Brief. Ottawa: Africa Indigenous Knowledge Research Network (AIKRN). Available online: https://www.researchgate.net/publication/386104052_The_Relevance_of_African_Indigenous_Knowledge_Systems_for_Development_in_Africa (accessed on 23 April 2025).
Osman, Anwar. 2009. *Indigenous Knowledge in Africa: Challenges and Opportunities*. Inaugural Lecture Paper. Bloemfontein: University of Free State.
Ramose, Mogobe B. 2002. *African Philosophy Through Ubuntu*. Harare: Mond Books.
Resane, Kelebogile T. 2022. *Puo Pha!*: African theology is a public theology of dialogue. *In die Skriflig* 56: a2859. [CrossRef]
Sakupapa, Teddy C. 2017. Ecclesiology and Ethics: An Analysis of the History of the All Africa Conference of Churches (1963–2013). Ph.D. dissertation, The University of the Western Cape, Cape Town, South Africa.
Sakupapa, Teddy C. 2018. The decolonising Content of African Theology and the Decolonisation of African Theology. *Missionalia* 46: 406–24.
Smit, Dirkie. 2007. What does "public" mean? Questions with a view to public theology. In *Christian in Public: Aims, Methodologies and Issues in Public Theology*. Edited by Len Hansen. Stellenbosch: AFRICAN SUN MeDIA, pp. 11–46.
Smit, Dirk J. 2017. Does it matter? On whether there is method in the madness. In *A Companion to Public Theology*. Edited by Sebastian Kim and Kettie Day. Leiden: Brill, pp. 67–94.
South African Government. 2004. Available online: https://www.dsti.gov.za/images/pdfs/IKS_Policy%20PDF.pdf (accessed on 23 April 2025).
Van Rooyen, Jurie S. 2019. The Relationship Between African Traditional Religion and Governance in South Africa. Master's thesis, University of the Free State, Bloemfontein, South Africa.

Disclaimer/Publisher's Note: The statements, opinions and data contained in all publications are solely those of the individual author(s) and contributor(s) and not of MDPI and/or the editor(s). MDPI and/or the editor(s) disclaim responsibility for any injury to people or property resulting from any ideas, methods, instructions or products referred to in the content.